

Ontology



Considered to be the major branch of metaphysics, ontology is the field of philosophy that examines the nature of existence and reality. It is distinct from epistemology in that it is not concerned with our knowledge of a thing, but addresses the questions of whether something actually exists, and what sort of things can be said to exist.

As well as trying to establish what can be said to exist, ontology also attempts to identify the properties of the things that exist, and categorize them according to these properties and the relationships between them.

Naturally, this entails an examination of the meaning of the terms 'existence', 'being' and 'reality' – a central concern of ontology – and concepts such as the substance or essence of an object, its identity and the difference between concrete and abstract objects: can concepts such as 'love' and 'memory' be said to exist in the same way as a table or a rock?